

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 226

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Foothills Land Conservancy on the occasion of its fortieth anniversary.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we specially recognize those estimable organizations that are dedicated to improving the quality of life of the people of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, one such organization is Foothills Land Conservancy, a regional land trust dedicated to protecting, preserving, and enhancing the lands and environment of the Southern Appalachian region, while also promoting the character of the land for the benefit of the general public; and

WHEREAS, celebrating its fortieth year of service as a regional land trust in 2025, Foothills Land Conservancy (FLC), through the tremendous investment and leadership of William "Bill" Clabough and the efforts of FLC's board of directors and staff, has assisted in the land preservation of more than 200,000 acres, including 500 conservation projects in Tennessee and the six surrounding states of Alabama, Georgia, Kentucky, North Carolina, South Carolina, and Virginia; and

WHEREAS, FLC was chartered in 1985 and granted tax-exempt status as a 501(c)(3) corporation; soon afterward, in 1987, former Governor Lamar Alexander joined and publicly endorsed the organization; and

WHEREAS, FLC assists landowners desiring to permanently preserve their property in its natural state, or as a working farm, primarily through the utilization of a legally binding conservation easement agreement; and

WHEREAS, within the State of Tennessee, FLC's land conservation projects now span fifty-two counties that include over 250 landowner partnerships and in excess of 100,000 acres preserved; and

WHEREAS, FLC assisted in the permanent conservation of Blount County's beloved Camp Montvale, seven Tennessee Century Farms, Jarvis Park in Blount County, an additional 1,000 acres of land transferred to the Mount Roosevelt State Wildlife Management Area in Roane County, and 649 acres of land in Polk County, which was transferred to the Tennessee Wildlife Resources Agency (TWRA); and

WHEREAS, the conservancy's board and staff worked to create a permanent foundation for planned gifts that includes land acquisition and stewardship programs, the Land Preservation Fund, and other conservation-related projects; and

WHEREAS, FLC worked with the TWRA and Ducks Unlimited to purchase the Kyker Bottoms Wildlife Refuge, a 524-acre wetland in Blount County, in 1998; managed by TWRA and open to the public, the refuge includes fields, forests, wetlands, and thickets and is managed primarily for waterfowl, shorebirds, and diverse nongame, especially songbirds; and

WHEREAS, in 2001, FLC, in collaboration with the TWRA and the Conservation Fund, assisted in the conservation of 2,500 acres at the Yuchi Wildlife Management Area at Smith Bend on Chickamauga Lake; located on the Chickamauga Reservoir near Chattanooga, Yuchi is owned and managed by the TWRA and includes wetlands, uplands, and riparian habitat, one of a string of nearby refuges and natural areas providing feeding/resting habitat for migrating waterfowl and sandhill cranes; and

WHEREAS, FLC's founding member, Gail Harris, placed a conservation easement agreement on her 300-acre working farm with FLC in 2009; the land, purchased by the grandfather of Gail Harris's late husband, Jim Harris, dates back to the late 1800s and originally

covered 1,000 acres. The property now includes woodlands, a spring fed pond, and a former dairy barn; and

WHEREAS, in 2016, Ms. Harris made the decision to transfer the property to the conservancy, which is now the site of FLC's headquarters, while roughly two-thirds of the Harris Farm continues to be leased for the production of corn, hay, soy beans, and cattle; and

WHEREAS, FLC amicably acquired the Southeast Regional Land Conservancy, which was based in Asheville, North Carolina, in 2023; this collaboration between two regional land trusts provided FLC with 140 additional conservation partnerships totaling more than 35,000 preserved acres; and

WHEREAS, the leadership, board, and staff of FLC work diligently to protect, preserve, and enhance the lands and environment of the Southern Appalachian region, and they are most worthy of our approbation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Foothills Land Conservancy on the occasion of its fortieth anniversary and extend our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.